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BOYS BASKETBALL REGIONAL FINALS

DIVISION III

Vikings move on without Lighty, head to state

TIM WARSINSKEY
Plain Dealer Reporter

CANTON — David who?

Rest assured, Villa Angela-St. Joseph hasn't forgotten David Lighty, the guard who led VASJ to the state final last year before helping Ohio State reach the Sweet 16 this weekend.

But as far as the Vikings were concerned this winter, they had to forget about him before getting back to Columbus.

"That's been our motivation all year," VASJ junior guard Ashen Ward said. "We had to find our own identity and show people that we are a good basket

VILLA ANGELA-ST. JOSEPH 55
LUTHERAN WEST 52

ball team." The Vikings proved as much in Saturday night's dramatic 55-52 regional-final victory over Lutheran West in Memorial Fieldhouse.

Ward hit the game-winning basket, a 16-foot jumper that broke a 52-52 tie with eight seconds remaining.

He took a pass from point guard Nate Barnes, who dished off after penetrating the lane, and Ward pump-faked a 3-pointer before stepping inside the arc.

"Nate and I have a connection after playing together so long. He made a great move to the basket and found me and I was wide open," said Ward, who

was held to 10 points by a tenacious Lutheran West defense.

Lutheran West, which hit numerous clutch shots in the second half, misfired from the right wing in the final seconds.

VASJ's Maurice Haynes grabbed the rebound, was fouled and added free throw with nine-tenths of a second to play.

"Ward hit a big shot and we got what we wanted when we got back down," Lutheran West coach Phil Argento said. "We got a nice look and it just didn't fall."

Lutheran West, which graduated seven seniors from last season's team, finished 22-2.

Junior center Mike Telzrow had 21 points and 16 rebounds.

VASJ junior post Klein Harper (11 points, 11 rebounds) helped the Vikings start the fast break in the second half to free up Ward and Barnes (11 points, one assist) from the Longhorns' triangle-and-two defense.

Forward Maurice Haynes had 14 points and eight rebounds.

VASJ (18-7), which had not been to the state tournament since 1997 until last year, plays in a state semifinal Thursday against Liberty Benton (25-0).

Lutheran West led most of the game. Its widest gap was 23-10 in the second quarter, which VASJ cut to 27-22 at

halftime.

The Vikings trailed by one point six times, including 39-38, after three quarters. VASJ finally grabbed a 46-44 lead on Barnes' 3-pointer three minutes into the fourth quarter.

Five points and a steal by Dave Mancini gave Lutheran West its final lead, 52-51, with 1:40 to play. VASJ forward Ben Shoaff split two free throws for the tie that Ward eventually broke.

"That was one of the gutsiest performances I've ever been involved in," VASJ coach Dave Wojciechowski said.

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DIVISION I

GlenOak goes on

Koufos helps carry Eagles to Columbus

CARL MATZELLE
Plain Dealer Reporter

Canton GlenOak's tall timber,

GlenOak 83
Firestone 50

7-2 center Kosta Koufos, helped dispatch another Greater Cleveland boys basketball team on Saturday.

The Ohio State-bound player dominated as GlenOak defeated Akron Firestone, 83-50, in a Division I regional final before a crowd of 4,374 at the University of Akron's Rhodes Arena.

The Eagles (23-3), who began the season at 3-3, are making their first trip to the final four in Columbus. And Koufos, who led all scorers with 30 points, has soared all season long. He almost had another triple double (16 rebounds, eight blocked shots), similar to his 22 points, 12 rebounds and seven blocked shots in Wednesday's 48-33 drubbing of Solon.

"God has blessed me with a great coach, great teammates, a terrific body and talent," Koufos said. "It's an honor to be playing in the state tournament."

But his teammates have shouldered the burden, too. Freshmen T.J. Sutton and Storm Sanders have become important cogs in the Eagles' machine.

Sutton, who finished with 11 points, including three 3-pointers, gets better every game, while Sanders finished with five points, but his keen eye led to 12 assists and ignited the team.

"Like a couple of sponges, they've been soaking up experience all season," Eagles coach Jack Greynolds Jr. said. "And they'll continue to get better, too."

GlenOak senior guard Mike Lancia, who scored 17 points, kept the pressure on the Falcons all night. In the third quarter, Lancia picked up three quick fouls, composed himself and nailed back-to-back 3-pointers.

"I didn't agree with the calls, but I told myself to stay cool, and the shots started falling."

Firestone players were determined to play better against GlenOak than they did in Thursday's comeback victory against Glensville, where the Falcons (19-6) were out rebounded, committed 21 turnovers and shot 37 percent from the field.



Firestone's Scott Boykin, left, tries to take the ball from GlenOak's Kosta Koufos.

STATE SCHEDULE

All games at Value City Arena, Columbus

Division I

Friday

GlenOak (24-3) vs. Cin. St. Xavier (21-5), 5:15

Cin. Moeller (24-2) vs. St. Edward (25-0), 8:30

Saturday, March 24

Championship, 8:30

Division II

at Value City Arena, Columbus

Thursday, March 22

Columbus St. Francis DeSales (22-3) vs. Dayton Dunbar (22-4), 5:15

Upper Sandusky (22-3) vs. Poland Seminary (23-3), 8:30

Saturday, March 24

Championship, 2

Division III

at Value City Arena, Columbus

Thursday

Liberty-Benton (25-0) vs. Villa Angela-St. Joseph (18-7), 10:45 a.m.

Wheelersburg (23-2) vs. Cin. North College Hill (16-7), 2

Saturday, March 24

Championship, 10:45 a.m.

Division IV

at Value City Arena, Columbus

Friday

Holgate (17-8) vs. Canal Winchester Harvest (24-0), 10:45 a.m.

Georgetown (26-0) vs. Berlin Hilland (23-4), 2

Saturday, March 24

Championship, 5:15

Game Balls

Vote for the top boys basketball performer from Saturday's regional finals on

cleveland.com/tlr. Voting is open until noon Tuesday. See who won Thursday in The Locker Room.

The contenders:

Delvon Roe and Matt Salay, St. Edward

The junior forward and senior guard, respectively,

combined for 37 points as the Eagles soared over Findlay in a 66-50 regional final win. Roe also snagged 11 rebounds, two assists and two steals; Salay chalked up six 3-point shots.

Maurice Haynes and Klein Harper, VASJ

The Vikings sealed a 55-52 regional final victory over Lutheran West on Saturday.

Haynes, a senior post player, drove in 14 points and scooped up eight rebounds.

Harper, a junior center, earned 11 points and hustled to get 11 rebounds.

Eagles flying south for the spring

MIKE PETICCA

Plain Dealer Reporter

TOLEDO — Opponents could try to deny the low-post game or contest the outside shot. It didn't matter to St. Edward. For the Eagles, there was more than one way to get to Columbus.

"When you're 25-0 and ranked first in the state, you have a lot of options," Eagles coach Eric Flannery said after St. Edward's 66-50 victory over Findlay in Saturday's regional championship game before about 4,000 fans at the University of Toledo.

"Our team is not a one-man show. People hear about Delvon Roe, who is a tremendous player and person, but they don't always hear about the other seven or eight guys who always step

ST. EDWARD
FINDLAY 66
50

up. I'm really happy these guys are getting to experience this."

St. Edward, ranked eighth in the nation by USA Today, will play Cincinnati Moeller (24-2) in a Division I state semifinal game on Friday night at Ohio State's Value City Arena.

Eagles senior guard Matt Salay took advantage of a zone defense that Findlay (21-4) played in the first half to try to negate 6-8 forward Roe and 6-8 center Tom Pritchard.

Salay took eight shots in the game — all 3-pointers and all in the first two quarters — and hit six of them. His marksmanship sparked St. Edward to a 34-24 halftime lead.

"If they are going to lay off the

perimeter, we have to try to make them pay for it," Salay said.

Roe and Pritchard, both juniors, took over in the second half after the Trojans switched to a man-to-man defense. Roe, who is being recruited by some of the nation's premier college programs, scored nine of his 19 points in the first four minutes of the third quarter, boosting the Eagles' lead to 46-31. Pritchard scored six of his nine points after the break and finished with 10 rebounds, one less than Roe.

"It's great, because there's not as much pressure on you," Roe said of the effect St. Edward's outside shooting has on his game. "You get double-teamed, and you just kick it out for the

open shot."

Junior point guard Frankie Dobbs had eight assists for St. Edward and senior forward Kyle Hubbard scored 10 points. The Eagles, who finished 10-of-18 on 3-pointers, grabbed 38 rebounds to 21 for Findlay. St. Edward's man-to-man defense limited the Trojans to 39 percent field goal shooting.

"We had to protect from inside-out and make them shoot the ball from outside," said Findlay coach Jim Rucki, who coached Rocky River from 1989-99. "They might miss those shots. You have to take that chance."

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DIVISION II

Diebler, fouls leash hindered Bulldogs

MIKE PETICCA

Plain Dealer Reporter

TOLEDO — Olmsted Falls basketball coach Pat Donahue could not have imagined the Bulldogs' season ending as it did, with four substitutes on the court in the late moments of a close game.

"Upper Sandusky deserves all the success they've had, and I hope they win the state championship," Donahue said after the Bulldogs lost Saturday night's regional championship game, 91-81, to Upper Sandusky before more than 7,000 fans at the University of Toledo.

"You can't play that team with subs, and that's what we were forced to do. I had never had more than one guy foul out of a game in more than 18 years of coaching."

Donahue was baffled that five Bulldogs fouled out.

Upper Sandusky took 47 free throws, and made 33 of them, while Olmsted Falls was 9-of-13 at the foul line.

Senior guard Dave Pellerite and his brother Pat, a junior guard, fouled out for Olmsted Falls midway through the fourth quarter, and senior forward Kyle Bungard was forced to leave with three minutes left.

The Bulldogs' all-Ohio senior guard, Tyler Sparks, hit a 3-point shot to cut what had been a 74-66 Rams' lead to 81-79 with 2:23 left, but fouled out six seconds later.

Olmsted Falls finished 22-3. Upper Sandusky (22-3) will play Poland Seminary in a Division II state semifinal game on Thursday night at Ohio State's Value City Arena.

UPPER SANDUSKY 91
OLMSTED FALLS 81

Dave Pellerite scored 24 points,

while Sparks totaled 17 points, 14 rebounds, seven steals and five assists. Senior forward Alex Sedlay, who fouled out in the final minute, scored 12 points and Pat Pellerite had 10.

Upper Sandusky guard Jon Diebler, Ohio's all-time scoring leader, scored 32 points to boost his career total to 3,136, and Rams sophomore guard Alex Falk had 24 points.

Diebler, an Ohio State recruit, was taken to a local hospital after the game with a broken nose that he sustained on a drive to the basket with 3:46 left. The game was delayed for about 20 minutes before the 6-7 Diebler was helped off the floor. He returned to the game wearing a mask and his nose packed with cotton with 2:28 to go and the Rams ahead, 81-76. He responded to the standing ovation in his honor by getting three points, three rebounds, an assist and a steal the rest of the way.

"He is the best player I've faced since I've been coaching," Donahue said of Diebler, who is scoring 41.2 points per game this season.

The game's pace was frantic, fitting the style of both teams. Olmsted Falls scored 42 fast break points to 32 for Upper Sandusky.

"They were very, very athletic," Keith Diebler, the Rams' coach and Jon's father, said of the Bulldogs. "They never quit. They are a great team. They're a complete team."

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Bengals tripped heading up steps

TIM WARSINSKEY

Plain Dealer Reporter

CANTON — Benedictine wanted to take one more step than it did last season, and then another, and then maybe more. The Bengals got that extra step, reaching Saturday's Division II boys basketball regional final in the Canton Civic Center.

Just as it was about to make the leap to the state semifinals, Benedictine's tournament trail was choked off by resilient Poland Seminary, whose fourth-quarter heroics continued in a 69-58 victory.

High school basketball is over for Benedictine's six seniors, but an impressive young core returns, including promising freshman starters Derek Jackson, a savvy point guard who scored 10 points, and 6-3 forward Cameron Wright, who scored 13.

In a somber locker room, coach Rob Stircula hugged his players, thanked the seniors and told the youngsters to be ready to work harder next season.

"Last year when we lost to Triway (in the regional semifinals), we made a commitment to make one more step," Stircula said. "Our next step is to get to state. The freshmen said we're going to go to three [state tournaments]. Hopefully they'll live up to it."

Senior guard Aaron Horn's 15 points led Benedictine (15-11). Poland advanced its first final four since losing to St. Vincent-St. Mary and LeBron James in 2002. The Bulldogs (22-3) play

POLAND SEMINARY 69
BENEDICTINE 58

Upper Sandusky on Thursday.

Benedictine led most of the game, including 10-point leads in the second and third quarters.

A 50-49 lead at the start of the fourth quarter quickly disappeared in a hail of forced shots, missed rebounds, fouls and turnovers. Poland, which played zone most of the first three quarters, switched to a man-to-man defense in the fourth, and the Bengals missed their first nine shots and committed three turnovers.

"We started to hurry up our shots and were playing like there was one minute left when we had a whole quarter," said senior Dan Reilly, who scored seven points.

A quartet of Poland players combined to make their first four shots of the fourth to go ahead, 56-51. The lead grew to 62-52 with 1:40 remaining and the margin could have been more, but the Bulldogs missed five straight free throws.

Benedictine senior Martin White made two free throws, and Wright stole the ball and scored, slicing four points off the deficit with 1:16 to play. Poland secured the win at the line, making 8 of 9 foul shots as time ticked away.

Poland made 25 of 37 free throws. Senior guard Chris Lovell (18 points) and senior center Lou Coppola (22 points) were a combined 15-of-18 at the line.

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